我为什么学中文

买和卖，水饺和睡觉

Why I Learn Chinese

Buying and selling, dumplings and sleep

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Footnotes mark names and words above HSK 2 (HSK 3.0 lists: github.com/ivankra/hsk30, MIT).

1 我叫本，是英国†人，今年二十二岁。两年以前，我来到北京学中文。来中国以前，我以为中文不太难。我想："我会说英语，也会说一点儿别的外语，中文有什么难的？"可是到了北京，我才知道，中文的四声太难了。

我想买，不想卖

2 来北京的第一个星期，我去学校旁边的水果店买水果。卖水果的是一个老人，我很想用中文跟他说话。我说："你好！我要卖水果。"老人看看我，又看看他的水果，问："你要卖水果？你的水果在哪儿？"

3 我不明白他的意思，又说了一次："我要卖水果！"老人笑了："年轻人，你是要买，还是要卖？"原来，我说的不是"买"，是"卖"！"买"是第三声，"卖"是第四声。

† 英国 *Yīngguó* Britain

My name is Ben. I'm British, and I'm twenty-two. Two years ago I came to 1
Beijing to study Chinese. Before I came to China, I thought Chinese wouldn't be very hard. I thought, "I speak English and a bit of another foreign language. What's so hard about Chinese?" But when I got to Beijing, I found out that the four tones of Chinese are really hard.

I Want to Buy, Not to Sell

In my first week in Beijing, I went to the fruit shop next to the university to 2
buy some fruit. The man selling the fruit was old, and I really wanted to talk to him in Chinese. I said, "Hello! I want to sell fruit." The old man looked at me, then at his fruit, and asked, "You want to sell fruit? Where's your fruit?"

I didn't understand what he meant, so I said it again: "I want to sell fruit!" 3
The old man laughed. "Young man, do you want to buy or to sell?" It turned out I hadn't said "buy", I had said "sell"! "Buy" (mǎi) has the third tone, and "sell" (mài) has the fourth.

3 我以为我说的是“买”，可是老人听到的是“卖”。那天，我虽然买到了水果，但是心里很不高兴。

睡觉还是水饺？

4 过了一个月，我和同学去饭馆吃饭。我很喜欢吃饺子，看了看菜单，就大声说：“我要一碗睡觉！”饭馆里的人都笑了。饭馆的女孩子也笑着说：“睡觉？我们这儿有水饺，可是没有睡觉。你想睡觉，要回家睡。”

5 我的脸一下就红了。“水饺”和“睡觉”，我听起来差不多一样，可是中国人听起来很不一样。那天晚上，我在房间里想：“中文太难了。我已经学了这么长时间，还是说不好。我不想学了。”从那天起，我越来越不想说中文，上课的时候也不想说话。

I thought I was saying "buy", but what the old man heard was "sell". That day I did get my fruit, but I wasn't happy at all. 3

Sleep or Dumplings?

A month later, I went to a restaurant with some classmates. I love dumplings, so after a glance at the menu I said loudly, "I'd like a bowl of sleep!" Everyone in the restaurant laughed. The girl working there laughed too and said, "Sleep? We have boiled dumplings here, but no sleep. If you want to sleep, you'll have to go home." 4

My face went red at once. To me, "shuǐjiǎo" (boiled dumplings) and "shuìjiào" (sleep) sounded almost the same, but to Chinese people they sounded completely different. That night, in my room, I thought, "Chinese is too hard. I've already been studying it for so long, and I still can't speak it properly. I want to give up." From that day on, I wanted to speak Chinese less and less, and in class I didn't want to say anything. 5

为什么学

6 有一天，我的中国朋友李明[†]请我喝茶。我跟他说：“我不想学中文了。我说中文，大家都笑我。”李明也笑了：“你以为就你一个人会说错吗？我给你讲讲我的英语吧。”

7 原来，李明在美国[‡]学过一年英语。有一次，他在饭馆里很饿，想说hungry（饿），可是说成了 angry （生气）。饭馆的人以为他很生气，马上问他：“对不起，是我们的菜不好吗？”李明说：“那天我很饿，可是大家都以为我在生气！”我听了，笑得说不出话。

8 李明说：“学外语，谁都会说错。说错了没关系，别人笑，你也笑。你说得越多，就说得越好。”我想了想：我为什么学中文？因为我喜欢中国，喜欢我的中国朋友，想跟他们说话。说错几句，没关系！

† 李明 *Lǐ Míng* Li Ming (Ben's friend)　　‡ 美国 *Měiguó* the United States

Why Learn?

One day, my Chinese friend Li Ming invited me for tea. I told him, "I don't want to study Chinese any more. Whenever I speak Chinese, everyone laughs at me." Li Ming laughed too. "Do you think you're the only one who makes mistakes? Let me tell you about my English." 6

It turned out that Li Ming had studied English in the United States for a year. Once he was very hungry in a restaurant and meant to say "hungry", but he said "angry" instead. The restaurant staff thought he was angry and immediately asked him, "We're sorry, is something wrong with the food?" Li Ming said, "I was really hungry that day, but everyone thought I was angry!" When I heard that, I laughed so hard I couldn't speak. 7

Li Ming said, "Everyone makes mistakes when they learn a foreign language. Mistakes don't matter. If people laugh, you laugh too. The more you speak, the better you'll speak." I thought about it. Why do I learn Chinese? Because I like China and my Chinese friends, and I want to talk with them. If I get a few sentences wrong, so what! 8

9 后来，我又天天说中文了。我去水果店，就跟卖水果的老人说几句；去饭馆，就跟饭馆的女孩子说几句。老人常常帮我练“买”和“卖”。有一天，他说：“你说得比以前好多了！”晚上，我还听中文歌，看中文电影。我能听懂的话越来越多了。

10 现在，我已经在中国两年了。我的中文越来越好，中国朋友也越来越多。虽然我还常常说错，但是我已经不怕了。上个星期，我又去了那个饭馆。我说得很慢：“我要一碗——水——饺。”饭馆的女孩子笑了：“今天不要睡觉了？”我也笑了：“今天不睡觉，今天吃水饺！”

After that, I started speaking Chinese every day again. When I went to the fruit shop, I chatted a little with the old fruit seller; when I went to the restaurant, I chatted a little with the girl there. The old man often helped me practise "buy" and "sell". One day he said, "You speak much better than before!" In the evenings I also listened to Chinese songs and watched Chinese films. I could understand more and more. 9

Now I've been in China for two years. My Chinese keeps getting better, and I have more and more Chinese friends. Although I still often make mistakes, I'm not afraid any more. Last week I went back to that restaurant. I spoke very slowly: "I'd like a bowl of... boiled... dumplings." The girl there laughed. "No sleep today?" I laughed too. "No sleep today. Today I'm having dumplings!" 10